

“She inhabited deserted tombs, and haunted graves from which the ghosts had been driven.”

LUCAN, *PHARSALIA*, 61–65 CE

marital spirit from Mars; oratory from Mercury; and ruling power from Jupiter. Predictions also caused the astrologers' downfall: in 16 CE a horoscope foretelling that Drusus Libo, a well-connected but dissolute aristocrat, might one day become emperor led to his arrest (and then suicide before his trial). In the aftermath of the scandal, all astrologers were expelled from Rome—part of a string of such purges, which had also taken place in 139 and 33 BCE; there were to be more in 69 and 89 CE.

Magic and the law

The Romans' fear of harmful magic ran deep. The Twelve Tablets of 451 BCE, Rome's first law code, prohibited spiriting away a neighbor's crops, and the Lex Cornelia of 81 BCE tightened up penalties for *veneficium* (malign magic). There were periodic mass arrests: in 331 BCE, 170 women were executed for giving out magical poison potions, while after Tiberius's arrest of Libo in 16 CE, 45 men and 85 women were executed for contravening laws on magic. Even high-profile Romans could fall foul of the law; in 158 CE the philosopher Apuleius of Madura was tried for using magic to seduce a rich widow, and only his eloquent defense speech acquitted him.

► Votive to Persephone

On this terra-cotta votive (religious offering) from southern Italy, Persephone is shown bearing a sheaf of wheat, a symbol of the renewed life brought by her annual return from the underworld in spring. As Queen of the land of the dead, she was often invoked in magical prayers and curses.



Necromancy

Some Romans practiced an even more feared form of magic. When Germanicus, adoptive son of Tiberius, died suddenly in 19 CE, rumor linked his death to magic. His room was said by investigators to be full of curse tablets, spells, and the remains of burned bodies. The latter was a sign of necromancy—magic involving the dead, who, it was held, passed messages to the gods and saw the future. Emperors with cruel reputations were rumored to use necromancy, too: Nero was said to have conjured the ghost of his mother, whom he had murdered, to beg her forgiveness.



IN CONTEXT

The fictional witch

The terrifying power of witches was a common theme in Roman literature. In Lucan's *Pharsalia* the witch Erichtho revivifies a corpse by pouring fresh blood and the spit of rabid dogs into it, while the poet Horace recounts the deeds of Canidia and her companion Sagana, whose activities include the kidnap and murder of children. With their horrific looks and renown for performing disgusting rituals, these fictional sorceresses are the literary ancestors of medieval witches.

Three witches prepare to receive a client in this Pompeii mosaic.